Question ID ff501705

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Math	Algebra	Systems of two linear equations in two variables	

ID: ff501705

$$\frac{3}{2}y - \frac{1}{4}x = \frac{2}{3} - \frac{3}{2}y$$
$$\frac{1}{2}x + \frac{3}{2} = py + \frac{9}{2}$$

In the given system of equations, p is a constant. If the system has no solution, what is the value of p?

ID: ff501705 Answer

Correct Answer:
6

Rationale

The correct answer is 6. A system of two linear equations in two variables, x and y, has no solution if the lines represented by the equations in the *xy*-plane are parallel and distinct. Lines represented by equations in standard form, $Ax + By = C$ and $Dx + Ey = F$, are parallel if the coefficients for x and y in one equation are proportional to the corresponding coefficients in the other equation, meaning $\frac{D}{A} = \frac{E}{B}$; and the lines are distinct if the constants are not proportional, meaning $\frac{F}{C}$ is not equal to $\frac{D}{A}$ or $\frac{E}{B}$. The first equation in the given system is $\frac{3}{2}y - \frac{1}{4}x = \frac{2}{3} - \frac{3}{2}y$. Multiplying each side of this equation by 12 yields $18y - 3x = 8 - 18y$. Adding $18y$ to each side of this equation yields $36y - 3x = 8$, or $-3x + 36y = 8$. The second equation in the given system is $\frac{1}{2}x + \frac{3}{2} = py + \frac{9}{2}$. Multiplying each side of this equation by 2 yields $x + 3 = 2py + 9$. Subtracting $2py$ from each side of this equation yields $x + 3 - 2py = 9$. Subtracting 3 from each side of this equation yields $x - 2py = 6$. Therefore, the two equations in the given system, written in standard form, are $-3x + 36y = 8$ and $x - 2py = 6$. As previously stated, if this system has no solution, the lines represented by the equations in the *xy*-plane are parallel and distinct, meaning the proportion $\frac{1}{-3} = \frac{-2p}{36}$, or $-\frac{1}{3} = -\frac{p}{18}$, is true and the proportion $\frac{6}{8} = \frac{1}{-3}$ is not true. The proportion $\frac{6}{8} = \frac{1}{-3}$ is not true. Multiplying each side of the true proportion, $-\frac{1}{3} = -\frac{p}{18}$, by -18 yields $6 = p$. Therefore, if the system has no solution, then the value of p is 6.

Question Difficulty:
Hard